Mirrors that reflect creativity

MADRAS.

The parched lands have not dried up the fountains of their imagination. On the other hand, adversity has nurtured and set off the springs of creativity with redoubled vigour, all of which is amply reflected in the wild yet tasteful use of colours in their handicrafts.

Jointly organised by the Crafts Council of India and the Gujarat State Handicrafts Emporium, Bangalore (Gurjari), the exhibition-cum-sale of the handicrafts of Gujarat was inaugurated by Mr P. Shankar, IAS, at the Sakshi Gallery, Khader Nawaz Khan Road on December 1.

'Gurjari' is the emporium of the Gujarat State Handicrafts and the Handloom Development Corporation.

The exhibits include brass pataris or jewel boxes, white metal anodized inlaid jewel boxes from Surat, a variety of bags and file folders, dandia sticks used in dances for Navarathri at the Tarnetar fair, embroidered umbrellas, garments (embroidered skirts, salwar kameez sets, cotton sarees, Kutch tie-and-dye sarees and traditional cholis — still the local dress of the womenfolk) quilts and shawls, dhurries, low stools and a variety of chappals.

A fascinating feature of all the handicrafts is the prominence of mirror work, which dominates in design.

Tending to the cattle outside and keeping an eye on the children crawling around in the house as well as watching the oven, the women's hands are all the time busy at her embroidery. The mirrors on the walls provide her with a view of the goings-on around her from where she sits. The mirror has thus become a dominant feature of their life, reflected in their handicrafts too.

It could also be the unquenched thirst for water, manifesting itself in the psychological need to have a mirage of water around them, muses Mrs. Lalitha Ubhaykar, Consultant for Gurjari in Bangalore.

The exhibition is open till December 9 from 10 a.m. to 7-30 p.m.

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